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Forced liminality and the indigenous peoples of Siberia in the wake of the Russia–Ukraine war

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines the impact of the Russia–Ukraine war on indigenous communities in Siberia and the Russian North, with particular attention to its implications for self-determination of a people and indigenous rights. Drawing on previous research, internet sources, and the author's field notes, the study employs a multi-sited chronological reconstruction method to trace developments across regions and ethnic groups over time. Within Russia's authoritarian context, some individuals align with the state by supporting the war and adopting an ethnic Russian identity. In contrast, others remain silent, avoiding explicit expressions of either support or opposition. Outside Russia, some become activists, criticizing the government while maintaining a strong sense of indigenous identity. In contrast, others, described as "silent migrants," prioritize personal safety, stability, and well-being over overt political engagement. The paper highlights political silence as a "forced liminality", observed both inside and outside Russia, as an important clue to understanding the suffering of those caught in the conflict. Ultimately, indigenous peoples face a stark dilemma: assimilate as russkie to survive as Russian citizens, or preserve their indigenous identity from abroad in conditions resembling diaspora.

1. Introduction: the war and new colonialism

How has the Russian invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 and the ensuing conflict, which has fundamentally altered the global order (hereafter, the "Russia–Ukraine War"), affected ethnic minorities and indigenous peoples? Many scholars have examined the war as a violation of the principle prohibiting the use of force in international relations, as set out in the UN Charter, and as a disruption of the post-war international political order (Matsuzato, 2023; Plokhy, 2023). By contrast, Adriana Petryna, a Ukrainian-born anthropologist known for her research on the Chernobyl disaster, offers a different perspective. She argues that Russia's refusal to designate the conflict as a 'war' reflects an imperialist stance. By labelling it a 'Special Military Operation,' Russia implicitly treats Ukraine as a quasi-state or internal colony rather than a sovereign equal. Petryna also identifies the emergence of a 'new colonialism.' She points to attacks on nuclear power facilities, occupation policies involving violence and forced displacement, and the disproportionate conscription of ethnic minorities and indigenous peoples for frontline combat (Petryna, 2023). From this perspective, the war should be analysed through the lenses of self-determination of a people and indigenous rights.

As an anthropologist, my previous research has focused on Siberian ethnology and interdisciplinary studies of climate change. My anthropological career began in the mid-1990s with ethnographic fieldwork on Eveny and Evenki reindeer herding and Sakha pastoralist systems. Building on this foundation, my research trajectory shifted in the 2010s toward a ten-year interdisciplinary investigation into environmental transformations, specifically focusing on ice-jam floods and the thawing of permafrost. I recognized the outbreak of war in 2022 as an injustice that must not be allowed to occur. However, I was soon struck by the scale of emigration from Russia, which intensified after the "partial mobilization" in September 2022, and by the fact that many indigenous populations were among those leaving. At the same time, indigenous people were participating in deployments to Ukraine, while anti-war movements were emerging both within and outside Russia. On a personal level, it was also unsettling to learn that an acquaintance of nearly 30 years long living in a Siberian Arctic village supported the government and the war. These developments prompted me to reconsider how indigenous peoples experience war and how indigeneity relates to armed conflict.

Against this background, this paper examines the broader transformation of Siberian and Russian North indigenous societies since the

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onset of the Russia–Ukraine War. Indigenous groups differ significantly in their historical, cultural, and political contexts, and individual experiences vary according to social and economic conditions. Generalizing across these groups is therefore difficult and risks reinforcing stereotypes. Nevertheless, from the perspective of Siberian studies, it remains valuable to provide a comprehensive account of how responses to the war are evolving. This paper reviews relevant literature on the conflict and incorporates findings from the author's field research and employs a multi-sited chronological reconstruction method to trace developments across regions and ethnic groups over time.

In Russian studies, a distinction is commonly drawn between "Indigenous Small-Numbered Peoples" (as defined by federal law) and "titular nations" (ethnic groups associated with specific autonomous okrugs or republics). Russian domestic law determines who qualifies as indigenous, restricting the populations of fewer than 50,000 individuals. This legal limitation directly contradicts the United Nations' framework on indigenous peoples, which emphasizes the primacy of self-identification and historical continuity against a backdrop of colonial history. However, since the 2010s, this distinction has become increasingly blurred amid the expansion of international indigenous movements (Takakura, 2021). The term "indigenous peoples" is used in this paper broadly to encompass both legally defined Indigenous Small-Numbered Peoples and titular nations who inhabited Siberia or Russian Arctic before the expansion of Imperial Russian rule.

The analysis presented here identifies several key features of changes: (1) transformations in indigenous societies within Russia before and after the war; (2) patterns of support for, and cooperation with, the war effort; (3) the limitations of anti-war opposition and the complexities of complicity; (4) the emergence of anti-war movements primarily outside Russia; and (5) the pursuit of stability and well-being among individuals who left the country to avoid conscription. This study examines these dynamics in detail and considers their broader implications.

This study contends that the Russia–Ukraine conflict has induced a state of forced liminality for the Indigenous Peoples of Siberia, trapping them in an unstable interstitial space. They are consequently forced to navigate a dichotomy: enduring systemic pressures toward political and cultural assimilation within the Russian Federation or attempting to safeguard their rights and heritage through the formation of a nascent diaspora in exile.

Drawing on the canonical work of an anthropologist Victor Turner, liminality represents a transitional phase within a rite of passage, during which participants occupy a fluid space between a former social position and a new one. This concept demonstrates that "marginal" or "liminal" zones within structured human societies can serve as catalysts for solidarity and integration, facilitating the dissolution of ascribed status and fostering an unstructured social phase (Turner, 1967). Crucially, while classical liminality is generated through the organic social processes of a community's own rites of passage, I argue that the liminality currently enveloping Siberian Indigenous societies has not emerged endogenously. Instead, it has been forcibly imposed upon them by the state. Through this theoretical lens, this paper seeks to examine the wider implications of the war for Siberian Indigenous peoples.

2. Methodology

2.1. Perspectives on indigenous peoples and ethnic minorities

This study is based on a literature review combined with the author's independent collection of online data. To date, several academic journals have published special issues on this topic, alongside numerous individual articles. However, given the ongoing nature of the war and the rapid emergence of new findings, it is difficult to provide a fully comprehensive review of the literature. Accordingly, this study identifies broad trends by examining journal special issues and edited volumes published between 2023 and 2025 that address Russia's indigenous peoples and ethnic minorities.

The first key source is a 2023 special issue of Inner Asia, published by the Mongolia and Inner Asia Studies Unit at the University of Cambridge, titled "Voices of Russia's Ethnic Minorities in the Invasion of Ukraine" (Bulag, 2023; Zhanaev and Jonutyte, 2023). The editor notes that the issue was conceived to address the lack of minority perspectives in discussions of the war and includes five articles. The second source is the three-volume compilation The Fractured North, published between 2024 and 2025 and co-edited by an ethnologist affiliated with a Siberian research institute in Germany, a North American anthropologist, and a geographer (Kasten et al., 2024). This collection contains 41 articles examining the war's impact on indigenous populations, its implications for Northern Studies, researcher–community relations, and the future direction of research in this field.

Third, the special issue "War and the State for Ethnic Minorities in Russia," published in volume 45 (2024) of Ethnologia Polona, includes 10 papers (Szmyt and Dudeck, 2024). The editors emphasize the significance of analysing ethnic minorities' participation in the war, focusing on their integration into state war policies and propaganda, the role of ethnic diversity in Russian military mobilization and armed conflict, and non-Russian responses to mobilization and its ideological foundations. I categorize these 57 papers to clarify the main research directions and the findings that have emerged to date.

Furthermore, I reviewed additional studies beyond the dataset described above to examine the relationship between Siberian indigenous peoples and the war. I also collected information from digital sources by accessing materials distributed through social networking services such as Telegram and Facebook, as well as from the International Committee of Indigenous Peoples of Russia (ICIPR) and the international NGO Cultural Survival. In addition, I conducted field research on indigenous refugees in Mongolia (Takakura et al., 2024; Takakura, 2025), and the local data obtained there are used as supplementary material.

2.2. Multi-cited chronological reconstruction

This paper analyses indigenous responses to the war documented in previous studies and digital sources, and my field materials while situating them within their regional contexts. To achieve this, I treat heterogeneous materials drawn from multiple media as a unified corpus of information on indigenous peoples and the war. By assembling these materials chronologically, I reconstruct the sequence of developments. I refer to this approach as "multi-sited chronological reconstruction," the methodological framework through which I examine the between Siberian indigenous peoples and the war.

Table 1 classifies the three sets of materials (57 papers) on Russian indigenous peoples and the war into broad thematic categories. The most frequent theme is "Reflection and Methodology" ($n = 27$). These studies provide reflexive accounts of the war's impact on researchers and explore alternative methods to compensate for the loss of conventional fieldwork. The second most frequent theme is "Responses to the War" ($n = 21$). Based primarily on internet-based research and studies

Table 01
Thematic categories of Russian indigenous peoples and the war.

	Topic	Number (n = 57)	Category
1	Reflection and Methodology	27	Refelection and Methodology
2	Local conditions	10	Responses to the War
3	Anti-war movemnets and emigration	7	
4	Perceptions and Representation	4	
5	History of the pre-war	4	History
6	Historical relations	5	

conducted outside Russia, this category includes: (1) local conditions, including cooperation with the war effort; (2) anti-war movements and emigration, largely occurring outside Russia; and (3) perceptions and representations of the war. The third theme is "History" ($n = 9$), which can be divided into (1) pre-war trajectories of indigenous societies from the collapse of the Soviet Union to the immediate pre-war period, and (2) analyses that situate the current situation within longer historical relationships among indigenous peoples, the state, and researchers, including those of the imperial era.

The prominence of "Reflection and Methodology" underscores the challenges faced by researchers who were abruptly cut off from their field sites and have sought ways to maintain connections with local communities and continue their work. That said, the direct effects of the war are not confined to the "Responses to the War" category; relevant information is also embedded within the "Reflection and Methodology" and "History" categories.

The set of materials presents the regions and ethnic groups covered in these studies. It encompasses a wide range of regions and ethnic groups both within and outside Russia, including Chukotka/Chukchi, Kamchatka/Itelmen, Kolyma, Sakha, Buryatia, Kalmykia, Transbaikal, Khanty, the Kola Peninsula/Sámi, Karelia, the North Caucasus/Circassians, and Chechnya. The geographical scope extends from Eastern Siberia to the European Russian Arctic, as well as Southern Siberia and the Caucasus. In addition, several studies examine Indigenous populations in urban centres such as Moscow and St. Petersburg, as well as those residing abroad in locations including Mongolia, Europe and USA.

These findings suggest two primary axes structuring the Russia–Ukraine War: conditions within Russia, where individuals are often compelled to align with government war policies, and anti-war movements developing outside the country. However, as both support for and opposition to the war may emerge in domestic and international contexts, I propose four analytical frameworks as a working hypothesis: pro-government or opposition and domestic or external to Russia (Fig. 1). This paper provides a schematic account of how Siberian indigenous peoples have responded to the war and is organized accordingly. Some might think on the trend should be explained by an emic perspective or the insider's view according to the vernacular term. However, the author adopts the etic perspective or the criteria from outside due to the fieldwork restrictions in Siberia. This is manifested in the political categorization in Fig. 1. Utilizing a literature review and existing fieldnotes, this paper evaluates these categories whether if to build a revised framework.

Emphasis should be placed on elucidating some tendency of the indigenous responses to the war based on a selected body of published research, rather than providing an all-encompassing literature review. My reference of the limit might remain open to being reinforced or challenged by the emergence of new other research or data sources.

3. Indigenous societies before the war: the case of the Chukotka Peninsula

Among the research themes introduced earlier is "pre-war history."

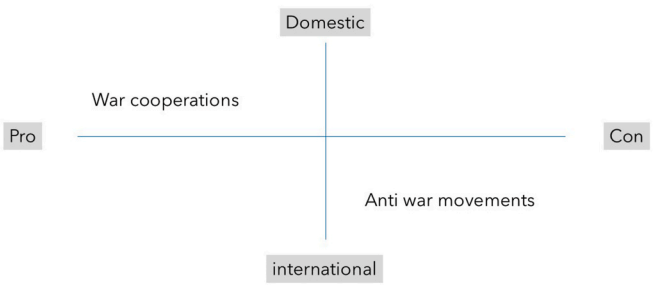


Fig. 1. Hypothesized framework for the indigenous peoples in the war.

This approach examines the historical trajectories of specific indigenous societies, outlines the conditions immediately preceding the war, and analyses the processes through which indigenous rights were progressively constrained. Here, using Chukotka (the Chukotka Autonomous Okrug) as a case study, I examine developments from the Perestroika period at the end of the Soviet era up to the eve of the war.

Chukotka is home to indigenous groups such as the Chukchi and Koryak, who speak Paleo-Asiatic languages; however, the present discussion focuses first on Yupiks, who belong to the Eskimo Aleut language family. Geographically, Chukotka lies only 86 km from the coast of Alaska, yet it is approximately 6200 km from Moscow.

Even before the formal demarcation of borders by Imperial Russia, Yupiks maintained close kinship ties and economic exchange networks with related groups on the Alaskan side. These cross-Bering Strait interactions continued after the establishment of the Soviet Union but were ultimately severed during the Cold War (Birch, 1988; Takakura, 2007).

These interactions resumed only after the onset of Perestroika in the late 1980s. In 1992, Yupik representatives participated in the Inuit Circumpolar Council, an international indigenous organization founded in North America that connects Inuit and related groups. This participation was significant in that it enabled Yupik communities on the Russian side to elect their own representatives and establish direct relations with other indigenous peoples, particularly those within the Eskimo language group (Gray, 2004; Naumova, 2024).

As in broader Russian society, the economic instability following the collapse of the Soviet Union had profound effects on indigenous communities. In response, several citizen-led organizations emerged in Chukotka. One example is the Union of Marine Mammal Hunters (UMMH), established in 1997. It aimed to protect the interests of hunters and to articulate grievances toward state-run enterprises. Although it facilitated cooperation among marine mammal hunters across settlements, the concept itself originated on the Alaskan side. As a result, local authorities regarded the organization with suspicion, interpreting it as a channel of American influence, and revoked its corporate registration in 1998 (Naumova, 2024).

Another example is the Naukan Production Cooperative. During the Soviet period, Yupiks were forcibly relocated from their ancestral settlements. Between 1958 and 1976, residents of Naukan, Nunyamo, and Pinakul were relocated to Lavrentiya, where they endured prolonged deprivation, including limited access to traditional marine-based food resources. In response to these conditions, they established the Naukan Production Cooperative in the late Soviet period. The cooperative successfully negotiated access to new hunting grounds and received darting equipment from the Alaska Eskimo Whaling Commission, which improved both efficiency and safety in whaling activities. However, in 2006, the cooperative was dissolved by an arbitration court due to outstanding debts. The official justification was that humanitarian aid, originally exempt from taxation, had been reclassified as taxable "technical assistance," thereby imposing a substantial customs burden on the cooperative (Zdor, 2024a). This outcome highlights the significant role of local administrative decisions in shaping the fate of indigenous institutions.

The final example is the World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF), an international NGO that began operating in Chukotka in 2004. The WWF sought to promote environmental conservation by designating marine mammal hunting areas in Chukotka as national parks, an initiative that initially received support from then-President Dmitry Medvedev. However, when offshore oil extraction began in these waters in 2014, a complex four-way conflict emerged among the central government, local authorities, indigenous communities, and the international NGO. In 2021, a parliamentary deputy representing Chukotka appealed to the Minister of Defence to prevent Russian territories from being "conquered" by the "green agenda." Following the outbreak of war in 2022, local authorities intensified their criticism, portraying WWF activities in Chukotka as a threat that alienated residents. Consequently, in

2023, the WWF was designated a "foreign agent" and included in the state registry of extremist organizations (Naumova, 2024).

These case studies illustrate the growth of indigenous rights movements in Chukotka and the processes through which authorities subsequently curtailed them. In the 1990s, cross-border interactions among indigenous peoples contributed to the strengthening of rights related to traditional livelihoods in Russia. However, since the late 1990s, local authorities have increasingly displayed hostility toward international indigenous rights initiatives and civic environmental movements, actively working to suppress them. Notably, indigenous organizations have repeatedly been criticized for their connections to foreign actors, and these alleged ties have served as a primary justification for their restriction. This reflects a broader historical pattern in which civic-oriented indigenous movements, which briefly expanded during the 1990s, were later reclassified as foreign (Western)-influenced entities and curtailed under the pretext of safeguarding state security. Notably, such an oppression of the local authority against the internationally connected indigenous movements had existed for more than two decades before the current war began.

4. Cooperation with the war effort within Russia

4.1. *The "home front" and internal divisions*

I turn now to government support within Russia. First, continuing from the previous section, I focus on developments in Chukotka. Some anthropologists established close relationships during fieldwork conducted before the COVID-19 pandemic and the war. Since the pandemic, they have continued to gather information by maintaining contact with local communities through digital media such as social media. The following example draws on such findings.

One researcher describes the final message exchanged with a close indigenous acquaintance, in contrast to a video of the same individual after the outbreak of the war. On February 15, 2022, they had an ordinary conversation about snowmobile parts. The next time the researcher encountered this individual was in a video recorded in front of a museum in Anadyr, the regional capital. In the footage, the individual displays the "Z" symbol and the "St. George's ribbon," both widely recognized as expressions of support for the Russian government and the war, while chanting, "We are Russians … Putin is our president" (Yamin-Pasternak and Pasternak, 2024).

This example suggests that, once the war began, assumingly, individuals were pressured to signal alignment with the state or risk marginalization. In my interpretation, it illustrates how, regardless of personal beliefs, individuals became acutely aware of their relationship to state power. On the other hand, these researchers must feel their emotional and ethical complexity facing when encountering such transformations among people with whom they have established close ties.

Another important aspect is that the individual identifies himself as "Russian as a russkii." This term may be interpreted as referring to a "Russian citizen" (rossiyanin), which can coexist with a distinct ethnic identity. However, in Russian, russkie (ethnic Russian) and rossiyanin (civic identity) are clearly differentiated terms,[1] and this distinction is important for understanding the implications of such self-identification.

In this context, the individual explicitly might identify as an ethnic Russian (russkie), effectively replacing his indigenous identity. The deliberate use of russkie by non-ethnic Russians in the context of the war (or the preceding two decades in Putin's regime) signals a rhetorical shift toward cultural assimilation, overshadowing the civic inclusivity implied by rossiyanin. The significance of this usage is illustrated by a pro-war banner displayed in April 2022 in Elista, the capital of the Republic of Kalmykia, a region inhabited by indigenous Mongolic peoples. The banner read: "I am Kalmyk [singular], but now we are all Russians [russkie or plural of russkii]." Baranova, who documents this case, argues that the category of ethnic Russians is strongly emphasized, effectively overriding the multi-ethnic framework guaranteed by the Russian Constitution (Baranova, 2024). This suggests that participation in the war promotes a form of national integration that pressures individuals toward assimilation into an ethnic Russian identity.

Chukotka is also home to the indigenous Chukchi people. For approximately 15 years, SNS has served as an important communication tool within these communities. Village-level chat groups have emerged, facilitating the exchange of information on the distribution and sale of marine mammal and whale products. A researcher with access to these chat groups analysed their content and found that one-sixth of men under the age of 30, as well as one-sixth of those aged 31 to 45, had left the village. Given that the community studied has a population of only 425, the departure of individuals to participate in the war is immediately visible to all residents. The researcher further notes that when men decide to enlist, the social bonds formed through cooperative marine mammal hunting play a significant role in that decision (Panakova, 2024). This finding highlights how social relationships embedded in traditional subsistence practices can directly influence life-altering decisions.

Another study examines wartime fundraising activities. At the beginning of the war, the conflict was not widely discussed within these SNS groups. However, as casualties from the local community became known, the deceased were commemorated as heroes, and support for the government began to increase. This trend intensified following the partial mobilization order in September. Among those involved in the private military company Wagner were individuals from the same ethnic background, including some recruited from prisons, and information about casualties was occasionally communicated through these networks. Subsequently, family members—particularly mothers and wives—began organizing clothing collections and financial donations. One example is a fundraising initiative conducted through the "Chukotka Front," a Telegram channel created by a Chukchi individual. It aims to supply soldiers with equipment, including medical supplies, generators, and vehicles. It is reported that 11 million rubles (approximately 15,000 USD) were raised within four months in 2023 (Kerghitageen, 2024). This rapid mobilization of resources suggests that indigenous communities have increasingly taken on roles in supporting the domestic war effort.

Furthermore, another researcher received the following letter from a local acquaintance in the summer of 2023. This correspondence describes the death of a soldier and the subsequent financial compensation: "[Name of the person] went to fight. And several others from our village are getting ready as well. Everyone is waiting for the war to end. No one wants to send their men there. There is a promise of a large payment, but they (the authorities) also run their own tricks. The very first mother from our village who buried her son received 12 million rubles (approximately US$130,000), bought an apartment in Anadyr, and, people say, drank away the rest" (Yamin-Pasternak and Pasternak, 2024). While participation in the war may yield substantial financial compensation, it does not necessarily translate into long-term well-being for families.

Reports from the indigenous Sámi of the Kola Peninsula, located west of the Ural Mountains, indicate deep divisions regarding the war. The Sámi are an indigenous people living not only in Russia but also across the Nordic countries, and since the 1990s, cross-border cooperation has developed around human and indigenous rights. As in Chukotka, such transnational cooperation has often been criticized by local authorities. At the same time, however, pro-government factions existed within

[1] In Russian, an important semantic distinction exists between two terms that are often translated simply as "Russian" in English. *Russkii* (русский) specifically denotes an ethnic Russian and carries cultural and historical connotations associated with the Slavic majority. By contrast, *rossiyanin* (россиянин) is a civic term that refers to any citizen of the Russian Federation, encompassing the country's diverse Indigenous and ethnic minority populations.

Sámi society before the war. In 2011, a Sámi activist initiated a project to construct a monument commemorating Sámi participation in World War II; the project received financial support from local authorities and mining companies, and the monument was completed in 2020 in Murmansk, the largest city on the Kola Peninsula (Vladimirova, 2024). This initiative can be interpreted as an effort to present indigenous peoples as loyal Soviet and Russian citizens. Around 2012, international connections within the Russian indigenous movement were increasingly curtailed by the state, and organizations were restructured to align with government positions; the Kola Peninsula Sámi Parliament followed this trajectory. Consequently, when the war began in 2022, the organization openly expressed support for the government (Zmyvalova, 2023;See also,Nagy, 2024).

A similar pattern can be observed in the Russian Association of Indigenous Peoples of the North (RAIPON), the largest indigenous organization in Russia. A letter expressing support for President Putin included the signatures of its president and vice president, as well as those of 31 indigenous representatives. At the 2024 United Nations Permanent Forum on Indigenous Issues, members of the Russian delegation introduced a Sámi politician who publicly declared support for the government and reported receiving state support for indigenous communities (Sulyandziga, 2024).

While expressions of support for the war among indigenous populations in urban areas share similarities with those in other Russian cities, they are distinguished by the added complexity of ethnic identity. In both Chukotka and the Kola Peninsula, indigenous movements grounded in transnational ethnic solidarity have been consistently constrained by the state. This reflects a broader condition in which only a limited form of multi-ethnicism is permitted. With the outbreak of war, however, the ethnic Russian identity (russkie) became more prominently emphasized in both contexts. Rather than suggesting a simple replacement of indigenous identity, this pattern indicates a form of coexistence. Supporting the war does not necessarily require the rejection of indigenous identity; rather, it appears that adopting an ethnic Russian national consciousness facilitates the form of integration expected under wartime conditions.

4.2. *Pressures and hardships*

With the onset of the war, attempts to organize anti-war movements and to avoid involvement in the conflict also emerged within indigenous societies. Here, I examine developments corresponding to "criticism of the government within Russia," one of the analytical frameworks outlined earlier.

A report provided by a student of indigenous background offers a revealing account. According to this testimony, following the outbreak of the war in 2022, university instructors began asserting that neo-Nazis control Ukraine, that Russian culture was under threat, and that Ukraine lacked genuine statehood. During the initial phase of the war, some students participated in anti-war demonstrations, while others hesitated. Soon afterward, however, universities reportedly began monitoring SNS to identify students expressing critical views and implemented "patriotism programs" targeting them. Students involved in protests faced police detention, and in some cases were expelled or arrested, receiving prison sentences of six to eight years. As a result, open dissent within the student body was effectively suppressed (Zdor, 2024b).

On September 21, 2022, the Russian government announced a "partial mobilization" to address personnel shortages, targeting 300,000 individuals.[2] In response, protests took place in Yakutsk, the capital of the Republic of Sakha, on September 25. These demonstrations were notable for the prominent participation of women, who protested through the Ohuokhai, a traditional circular dance. Participants voiced opposition to what they characterized as genocide and criticized the historical use of indigenous peoples as expendable forces during the Great Patriotic War (World War II). At the same time, these protests also encountered criticism from within Sakha society, where some groups advocated cooperation with the war effort. For example, the patriotic organization Us Tumsuu, established in 2016, mobilized approximately 5000 participants for a pro-government rally on April 22 of the same year (Habeck, 2023). This indicates that anti-war actions not only face state suppression but also generate divisions within indigenous communities themselves.

Politicians of indigenous background also pursued legislative efforts to secure exemptions from military service. On September 28, a member of the Russian State Duma and former mayor of Yakutsk proposed exempting indigenous peoples residing in designated protected areas from mobilization. On the same day, a deputy representing the Nenets Autonomous Okrug planned to introduce a bill to exempt reindeer herders, citing their importance for regional food security. Furthermore, on October 7, the president of the Association of Indigenous Peoples of Khabarovsk Krai appealed to the government to halt the mobilization of indigenous populations. None of these initiatives resulted in legislative change. The only proposal formally introduced as a bill, advocated by the former mayor of Yakutsk and other deputies, sought to grant indigenous peoples engaged in traditional livelihoods the right to substitute military service with alternative civilian service. This proposal was ultimately rejected (Zmyvalova, 2023).

The international NGO Cultural Survival provides information on how Indigenous communities responded to the partial mobilization order. According to its reports, the Russian Ministry of Defense did not set fixed quotas; instead, responsibility for mobilization was delegated to individual municipalities based on the number of citizens registered with the military. However, mobilization levels in practice often exceeded these implicit baselines.

On September 23, a former chairman of the State Assembly of the Sakha Republic, in an open letter addressed to President Putin and the Head of the Republic, described the situation as chaotic. The letter reported widespread concern among residents that conscription levels far exceeded what would be expected under proportional mobilization. It further noted that individuals eligible for deferment or exemption were being drafted. Arguing that these practices constituted serious violations of federal law governing military service and human rights, the author called for corrective action (Shamaev, 2022).

Among the materials reported by Cultural Survival was a case from the Olenyoksky Evenki National District in the Sakha Republic, an area where the author has previously conducted fieldwork (Takakura, 2012). An administrative document dated September 22, issued by the head of the district and addressed to the head of the Sakha Republic, requested a reduction in the mobilization quota from 50 to 25 individuals. The document explained that, out of a total population of 4,324, there were 2139 men, of whom only 128 were aged 18–35. Mobilizing 50 individuals would therefore amount to drafting 39.1% of this critical demographic group.[3] Additional context further complicates this issue. According to a researcher with field experience in the region, local administrations may have previously inflated population figures to secure higher levels of state subsidies. This practice may have inadvertently intensified the burden of mobilization quotas.[4] This suggests that the partial mobilization order caused significant disruption to local communities and imposed severe administrative pressure on local authorities.

Comparable situations have also been reported in the Amur region.

[2] https://web.archive.org/web/20220922065825/https://www.svoboda.org/a/shoygu-obyavil-o-mobilizatsii-300-tysyach-rezervistov/32044077.html (last accessed 23 March 2026).

[3] https://www.culturalsurvival.org/news/violations-indigenous-peoples-rights-republic-sakha-yakutia-during-partial-military (last accessed 23 March 2026).

[4] Personal communication, January 28, 2026.

The mobilization process lacked clear legal regulation, resulting in inconsistent implementation as local governments interpreted directives independently. According to a Nanai activist, men from his village had already been involved in military activities in the Donbas region since 2014, with many having lost their lives (Zmyvalova, 2023). Despite this, during the 2022 mobilization, draft summons addressed to deceased individuals were reportedly delivered to their bereaved families (Zmyvalova, 2023). Such incidents highlight the disorganization and administrative breakdown that characterized the mobilization process.

The Russian state effectively constrained public opposition to the war. Efforts by politicians of indigenous background to secure exemptions from conscription were unsuccessful. At the same time, the implementation of mobilization policies and cooperation with the war effort placed considerable strain on local administrations. In small and remote villages with limited populations, participation in the war effort created conditions that threatened the viability of traditional livelihoods and the demographic sustainability of these communities.

5. Indigenous movements and migration outside Russia

5.1. Anti-war movements

As outlined above, anti-war movements emerged within Russia immediately following the invasion of Ukraine; however, these movements were subsequently suppressed and gradually shifted their primary locus abroad (Aburamoto, 2022; Bygnes, 2026). This section examines the development of anti-government criticism outside Russia, drawing on the four analytical frameworks introduced earlier.

As noted above, RAIPON, Russia's largest indigenous organization, has maintained a pro-government position since 2013. On March 1, 2022, RAIPON issued a statement expressing support for the Putin administration. In response, dissenting actors established the "International Committee of Indigenous Peoples of Russia" on March 10 (Koresawa, 2024).[5] This organization has developed websites and social media platforms to disseminate information from indigenous activists and communities,[6] with a primary focus on human rights protection and resistance to political repression. These platforms include a substantial volume of content critical of both the government and the war.

The organizations described above are primarily led by groups classified under Russian law as "Indigenous Small-Numbered Peoples." At the same time, similar anti-war movements have emerged outside Russia among other indigenous populations that do not fall within this legal category, including the Sakha (Yakut), Buryat, Tuvan, and Khakas peoples (Zibrova, 2022). One example is the movement "New Tuva." Its initial activities involved activists operating abroad who used social media to disseminate information in Tuvan, including reports on casualties among Tuvan individuals. The movement later expanded its presence through platforms such as Instagram. Its stated objectives include supporting individuals who refuse military service, providing alternative sources of information, and discouraging participation in the war. Members of the movement interpret the conflict as a continuation of long-standing Russian imperial policies. While the Russian government justifies the invasion as a measure to prevent the "Nazification" of Ukraine, this organization instead frames Ukraine's actions as an expression of national self-determination (Khovalyg, 2023). Another notable organization is the "Free Buryatia Foundation." Established in the United States and the Czech Republic in March 2022, the organization engages in anti-war activities, volunteer work, and support for deserters. It also analyzes publicly available data on the participation of ethnic minorities in the war, thereby highlighting issues that are not addressed in official Russian media (Vyushkova and Sherkhonov, 2023).

In addition, the "Free Nations League" was founded in May2022.[7] This organization is characterized not only by its opposition to the war but also by its advocacy for the sovereignty of various indigenous peoples and territories within the Russian Federation. In addition, it functions as a collaborative network linking multiple indigenous and ethnic minority groups. As of 2023, it included representatives from regions and groups such as Bashkortostan, Buryatia, Cossackia, Erzyan Mastor, Mokshan Mastor, Oirat-Kalmykia, Karelia, Ichkeria, Ingria, Ingushetia, Sakha-Yakutia, and Tatarstan (Dolyaev and Dugar-DePonte, 2023).[8]

In July 2024, the Russian Ministry of Justice published a list of extremist organizations, designating 55 indigenous organizations—including those mentioned above—as entities engaged in "structural fragmentation and anti-Russian separatist movements," and labelling them as international terrorist groups. This list notably includes organizations such as Aum Shinrikyo and the Islamic State. At the 57th session of the UN Human Rights Council in 2024, it was reported that there is little prospect for improvement in the human rights situation of indigenous peoples in Russia, with particular attention drawn to the disproportionate conscription of indigenous populations and the pressure placed on anti-war organizations (IWGIA, 2025).

As seen in the pre-war context, cooperation between international indigenous movements and regions such as Chukotka has long been subject to restriction, including through the application of the "Foreign Agent Law." At present, the primary activities of these organizations consist of disseminating information in English and Russian from outside Russia via social media, offering perspectives that challenge official state narratives. Despite the limited scope of these activities, the government continues to regard them as significant threats, in part because they operate from abroad. Indigenous, anti-government, and anti-war organizations also vary in structure: some are organized around specific legally defined groups or individual ethnic communities, while others take the form of broader alliances encompassing multiple ethnicities.

5.2. Politicization of war casualties

Since the outbreak of the war, disparities in conscription rates across ethnic groups have been widely reported, including in mass media coverage.[9] At the same time, the difficulty of quantitatively assessing conscription and mortality rates by ethnicity has also been noted. This challenge stems from the fact that ethnic classification often relies on subjective identification rather than fixed or objective criteria (Watanabe, 2022).

Following a June 2022 ruling by a court in Kaliningrad, the disclosure of information concerning Russian military casualties in the Ukraine conflict was prohibited. The ruling determined that such information constitutes a military secret, thereby rendering the publication of casualty lists illegal.[10] Consistent with official terminology, the Russian government avoids the term "war" and instead refers to the conflict as a "special military operation." This policy of restricting information likely reflects concern that data on domestic casualties could enable citizens to evaluate the conflict's progress and outcomes

[5] https://indigenous-russia.com/archives/19347 (last accessed 23 March 2026).

[6] https://indigenous-russia.com/archives/261 (last accessed 23 March 2026).

[7] The first congress organized in Estonia. https://fennougria.ee/en/free-nations-league-organised-in-estonia/(last accessed 30 March 2026).

[8] As of March 2026, groups such as the Circassians and Chechens have also joined. https://freenationsleague.org/ru/(last accessed 23 March 2026).

[9] See, for example, the Yomiuri Shimbun article dated August 13, 2022 (https://www.yomiuri.co.jp/world/20220813-OYT1T50176/) [last accessed 23 March 2026] or the March 27, 2025 article by the US think tank Wilson Center (https://www.wilsoncenter.org/blog-post/russias-indigenous-communities-and-war-ukraine) [last accessed 23 March 2026].

[10] https://www.rferl.org/a/russia-ban-military-casualties/31887084.html [last accessed 23 March 2026].

independently.

Under these conditions, Russian online media outlets such as Meduza and Mediazona have continued to report on casualties associated with the "special military operation."[11] An analysis of war deaths by ethnicity, using machine-learning methods based on data available as of April 2023, indicates a disproportionately high number of casualties in regions inhabited by indigenous peoples. The study further shows that, even among ethnic republics, mortality rates are lower in regions with significant energy resources and substantially higher in economically disadvantaged areas lacking such resources (Bessudnov, 2023).

The anti-war organizations discussed in the previous section have also undertaken efforts to document casualties under these restrictive conditions. Beyond questions of numerical accuracy, the political significance of casualty figures in contemporary Russia deserves attention. According to a 2023 study, organizations such as the Free Buryatia Foundation, Chechen groups, Anti-War Kalmykia, the Free Sakha Foundation, Tatarstan groups, and New Tuva collaborated to construct a casualty database. This database drew on obituaries and information from local media and social networks, cross-referencing names, regions, birth years, and photographs. Based on 6287 recorded deaths as of September 2022, the study estimated casualty ratios by ethnicity. Although ethnic Russians comprise 80.9% of the population, they accounted for 70.6% of recorded deaths, yielding a casualty-to-population ratio of 0.87.

In contrast, Buryats, who represent only 0.34% of the population, accounted for 2.3% of deaths, resulting in a ratio of 6.8. The corresponding ratio for the Chukchi was 1.6. The authors emphasize that variation among different indigenous groups must be considered and note that proximity to military bases is a key factor influencing these disparities (Vyushkova and Sherkhonov, 2023).

While care is needed when directly linking indigenous participation in the war to economic deprivation, the disproportionate loss of life among indigenous populations cannot be ignored. Although distinct from wartime contexts, disaster studies have long emphasized that human loss should not be reduced to numerical counts alone, but should instead be understood in terms of the social significance of each death (Boret and Shibayama, 2018). Each casualty represents a named individual with a unique identity, and reducing such losses to statistics risks diminishing their human meaning. In this context, the Russian government's policy of restricting public disclosure of casualty information warrants critical examination from a humanitarian perspective. Under current conditions, even the act of attempting to document deaths within one's own community can carry implicit political significance for ethnic minorities.

5.3. Silent migrants

Thus far, I have examined the development of anti-war movements outside Russia. A Sámi activist, one of the founding members of the International Committee of Indigenous Peoples of Russia, sought political asylum in Norway in March 2022. Reflecting on this decision, he stated: "I left everything behind in Russia. Some people remained in their hometowns with their families and continued to live their lives. They chose not to protest. Whose choice was the right one?" (Zmyvalova, 2025). While some indigenous individuals have pursued asylum abroad with strong political convictions, others have followed different trajectories shaped by personal and social circumstances.

Drawing on my previous research, I introduce the case of Buryat individuals who relocated to Mongolia. Although a small number expressed anti-government views, sometimes framed through Pan-Mongolist perspectives, such cases were exceptional. Most did not articulate explicit anti-war positions. Rather, they left Russia either to avoid participation in the war or because they had lost confidence in the country's future. Notably, many reported that they only came to interpret the condition of indigenous peoples in Russia as a form of colonialism after leaving the country.

These individuals represent a subset of the broader wave of emigration that followed the partial mobilization order in September 2022. As in Central Asian countries, Mongolia permits Russian citizens to remain for up to 30 days without a visa. Consequently, many people, including ethnic Russians, moved from regions such as Irkutsk, Buryatia, and Sakha to Mongolia, with some subsequently relocating to third countries such as the United States and South Korea (Takakura et al., 2024).

In relation to this research, the situation of one evacuee and her partner, as documented by the author in 2024, is summarized as follows.

Case Study: The woman, originally from a rural area and not a Buryat speaker, graduated from a design school in Ulan-Ude and began working as a freelance designer. Following the mobilization order, her parents supported her decision to leave her hometown with her partner. She independently chose to accompany him, although the decision was not straightforward. Around June 2022, she had attended a music festival in Ulaanbaatar and developed an affinity for Mongolia, but she did not anticipate returning there so soon. Upon arrival, the couple faced difficulties due to a lack of stable housing, employment, and social connections. Facing these difficulties, they relocated to Thailand in November 2022. During this period, they came to recognize cultural affinities between Mongolian and Buryat traditions, which led her to return to Mongolia in February 2023. The couple married in the summer of 2024 and currently works in art-related fields. She reports experiencing a sense of personal freedom in Mongolia (Takakura, unpublished fieldnotes, November 6, 2024).

Cases of couples migrating together, as in the example above, are relatively rare; most individuals relocate on their own. The key point is not their level of political engagement, but that these individuals are living outside Russia in pursuit of personal well-being and freedom. They maintain frequent contact with family members in Russia through social media, and in some cases, relatives travel overland to Mongolia to visit them. Another characteristic of this group is their mobility, as they often change destinations in response to personal preferences and future opportunities.

I refer to such individuals as "silent migrants." These migrants cannot be easily categorized within the analytical frameworks proposed earlier. While they are not supporters of the Russian government abroad, they also do not engage in overt political activism. Nevertheless, it is worth recognizing the presence of indigenous individuals occupying this intermediate position. The silent migrants and the activists consist of "war migrants". This term is intended as a neutral category that avoids the political and social implications associated with labels such as "diaspora" or "refugees" (Fihel et al., 2025). Its use follows a common distinction in anthropology, where "migrants" denotes temporary movement, whereas "immigrants" implies long-term relocation without an expectation of return (Welsch and Vivanco, 2015). Accordingly, I define "war migrants" as individuals who temporarily leave their place of residence or country because of war.[12]

6. Discussion: Forced liminality

Based on the corpus of information on indigenous peoples and the war compiled through prior research, digital sources, and the author's

[11] https://en.zona.media/article/2025/10/10/casualties_eng-trl [last accessed 23 March 2026]; https://meduza.io/[last accessed 1 November 2025].

[12] The evacuees themselves also rejected the term "relocants" (*relokanty*) (Matsumoto, 2024), which is frequently used to refer to Russian evacuees in the context of the war. Similar responses emerged from inquiries to their supporters in Mongolia. When asked how they would classify the evacuees, respondents more often identified them as "Buryats" or simply "Russians." In Mongolia, ethnic Russians are typically referred to as "White Russians" (*tsagaan oros*).

fieldwork, an analysis employing multi-sited chronological reconstruction across Russia yields the following findings.

(1) Suppression of local movements: As early as the late 1990s, regional movements in Chukotka engaged in collaboration with international indigenous networks were subject to monitoring and suppression by local authorities. By the 2010s, similar patterns of control had extended to central Russia. The transformation of RAIPON, Russia's largest indigenous organization, into a pro-government entity is a clear example of this trajectory.
(2) Pro-government sentiment and assimilation: Following the outbreak of the war, pro-government movements emerged within indigenous communities in regions such as Chukotka, the Kola Peninsula and Kalmykia. These movements prioritize national integration over distinct ethnic identity. However, this integration does not take the form of inclusion within a civic national framework; rather, it reflects a tendency toward assimilation into an ethnic Russian identity.
(3) Domestic anti-war efforts and administrative strain: Until the spring of 2022, anti-war actions were undertaken by indigenous students in cities such as St. Petersburg and by residents in locations including Yakutsk. In addition, indigenous politicians in the Sakha Republic, the Nenets Autonomous District and Khabarovsk District attempted to introduce legal measures to secure exemptions from mobilization, but these initiatives were unsuccessful. At the same time, local administrations encountered significant challenges in implementing the partial mobilization announced in September 2022, revealing institutional limitations at the municipal level in Sakha Republic and Khabarovsk District.
(4) Manifestation and emergence of transnational anti-war networks: In response to increasing political constraints, anti-war movements developed outside Russia from March 2022 onward. These movements include organizations formed along ethnic lines—both among legally defined indigenous small-numbered peoples and other ethnic minorities—as well as broader coalitions spanning multiple groups. Their activities are primarily conducted through digital platforms, focusing on information dissemination and exchange. They have also undertaken independent analyses of war casualties by ethnicity, despite official prohibitions on such activities.
(5) Divergent motivations among expatriates: Among those who left Russia, distinct patterns can be observed. Some individuals sought political asylum immediately after the outbreak of the war in February 2022 and engaged in overt activism. Others, described as “silent migrants,” left primarily in pursuit of personal well-being and stability, while maintaining a more limited or indirect form of political engagement. The sense of freedom experienced by silent migrants represent a form of transnational Eurasianism, distinct from nationalist Soviet Eurasianism. This marks a qualitative shift, wherein individuals experience a sense of belonging within a broader Asian space.

This paper set out to provide a comprehensive assessment of the impact of the Russia–Ukraine war on indigenous communities across Siberia and Russian North. At the outset, the analysis was guided by a working hypothesis that organized cases into four domains defined by location (inside or outside Russia) and stance toward the government (criticism or support). Although this framework offered an initial structure, it proved insufficient for capturing the complexity of indigenous experiences in relation to the war. In particular, no clear evidence was found of indigenous individuals or groups outside Russia who openly support the government, which undermines one quadrant of the original model.

In light of this limitation, I propose a revised analytical framework (Fig. 2). This model is structured along two axes: a horizontal axis representing ethnic orientation and a vertical axis representing the degree

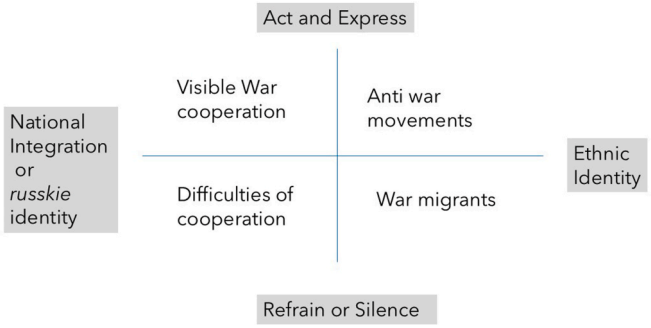


Fig. 2. Experience model for the indigenous peoples in the war.

of public political expression. On the horizontal axis, individuals range from strong identification with their specific indigenous ethnicity to stronger alignment with Russian national consciousness, expressed through the term russkie (ethnic Russian). In principle, being a Russian citizen (rossiyanin) is a civic identity that can coexist with a distinct ethnic identity. However, in Russia's currently dominant political discourse, this distinction has become exceedingly blurred. Citizens who genuinely support the war are, in effect, strongly pressured to identify as russkie (ethnic Russians). Civic nationality and ethnic identity, which could previously coexist, have now diverged in ways that force indigenous peoples to choose between them. On the vertical axis, individuals vary in the extent to which they publicly articulate their political stance on the war. This axis captures the choice between openly expressing one's position and refraining from doing so. The domestic anti-war actions observed until the spring of 2022 (discussed in Section 3) were subsequently either forced into silence by state repression or channelled into emigration. As a result, those who remain in Russia today fall largely into two groups: those who have accepted Russification by supporting the war and, in some cases, participating in mobilization, and those who remain silent, unable to act regardless of their views. Outside Russia, the distribution consists of individuals who engage in explicit anti-war activism while maintaining a strong sense of indigenous identity, alongside those who avoid politicization and remain silent.[13]

Both axes function as continua rather than fixed categories. As a result, individuals may be situated at varying points along each dimension, allowing for a more nuanced representation of shifting identities and forms of political engagement under conditions of war. Whereas the vertical axis of political expression pertains to Russian citizens irrespective of ethnicity, the horizontal axis concerning the adoption of russkie identity for national integration is relevant exclusively to Russia’s indigenous peoples and ethnic minorities, reflecting their distinct predicament.

What this model illustrates is the structural agony experienced by indigenous peoples confronted by the war. War inevitably forces a polarization of positions: pro or con, friend or foe. In response to this polarizing pressure, it has been argued that the role of anthropology lies in the “recovery of ambiguity” (Käihkö, 2020). If so, ethnographic accounts of those occupying the space of political refrain or silence in Fig. 2 provide crucial clues to understanding the suffering of people caught in this conflict. The agony of indigenous peoples extends beyond the fear of war itself. Under a concept of nationality in which civic and ethnic ties are conflated, they face a stark dichotomy: reject Russian

[13] As much of this study relies on secondary literature, fully reconstructing the ethnographic context of original sources remains challenging. This constraint also applies to single-occasion interviews in my own fieldwork, limiting my ability to grasp the subjective beliefs underlying observed behaviors. Consequently, there is a risk of underestimating the complex agency of Indigenous actors, especially when dismissing pro-war stances as mere products of state assimilation or external pressure.

citizenship to remain Indigenous, or deny their indigenous identity and assimilate as russkie to survive as Russian citizens. This situation can be characterized as "forced liminality."

In its original formulation by anthropologist Victor Turner, the concept of liminality highlights the agency of inter-structural "liminal personae" who catalyse the renewal of a community in its next developmental stage (Turner, 1967). However, the restoration of social structure is fundamentally contingent upon the clear-end of this liminal phase; indeed, when it remains open-ended, "without reintegration, liminality is pure danger" (Thomassen, 2009). As demonstrated in the preceding section, the Russian state has subjected Siberian Indigenous peoples to precisely this perilous state. Forced liminality, by definition, lacks a subsequent stage of reintegration since the other than one's will push a person to this liminality. It constitutes an unstructured, permanent state of suspension—a goal-deprived passage devoid of subsequent transition or final repositioning. Driven by state power entirely external to their own agency, this forced transition inevitably breeds acute anxiety, existential discomfort, and an inescapable experience. Although the pressures of war demand an immediate binary choice, Indigenous peoples often remain in a state of unarticulated political alignment or as a silent majority, navigating a blurred civic and ethnic identity.

7. Conclusion

The Russia–Ukraine war has imposed a limited set of pathways on indigenous communities, each shaped by political constraint and geographic location. Within Russia's authoritarian context, individuals may align with the state by supporting the war and, in many cases, adopting an ethnic Russian national identity. Alternatively, they may choose to remain silent, avoiding explicit expressions of either support or opposition. Outside Russia, two additional trajectories are evident: some individuals engage in activism, criticizing the government while maintaining a strong sense of indigenous identity, whereas others, described as "silent migrants," prioritize personal safety, stability, and well-being over overt political engagement.

The pursuit of international indigenous rights, which gained momentum following Perestroika, has been effectively curtailed within Russia under wartime conditions. For those who remain in the country, maintaining their indigenous identity leaves them with little recourse beyond passive resistance, such as quiet non-compliance with government directives.

A deeply ironic situation has emerged. Indigenous peoples are, by definition, groups characterized by historical continuity with ancestral lands and distinct cultures, whose very identity serves as a standing challenge to the historical injustices of colonization (Takakura, 2009). Yet today, the space to retain this identity and advocate for indigenous rights no longer exists within their homeland. It persists only for those who have left Russia. Even they, however, face significant challenges, particularly regarding legal residency and long-term security in host countries as Russian nationals. Indigenous peoples are now compelled to seek recognition and advocacy beyond the borders of the land that defines them as indigenous. This novel experience necessitates a rethinking of indigeneity as an identity grounded in ethnic, spiritual, or institutional dimensions, rather than being deeply rooted in a specific landscape. This represents a form of strategic essentialism (Bell, 2021) employed by these groups regardless of their overt political consciousness. It is crucial to emphasize that this phenomenon has emerged specifically among individuals experiencing a state of forced liminality. They endure this coerced ambiguity with discomfort, a state from which individuals can scarcely escape of their own volition.

In the social sciences, when a culturally coherent group becomes geographically dispersed beyond its original nation-state while retaining a shared identity, it is conceptualized as a diaspora (Colander and Hunt, 2019). The war has thus produced a structural condition in which indigenous peoples are increasingly caught between two constrained alternatives: remaining within Russia under pressure to conform politically and assimilate into a russkie (ethnic Russian) identity, or living abroad in what increasingly resembles an emerging indigenous diaspora, regardless of their level of political involvement. This is the result of the forced liminality imposed on indigenous peoples by the state. I conclude this paper by drawing attention to this paradox.

Conflicts of interest

The authors declare that there are no conflicts of interest regarding the publication of this paper.

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